SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

A PHENOMENOLOGICAL STUDY ON THE LIVED EXPERIENCES OF INCARCERATED LGBTQAI+ MEMBERS

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Incarceration represents a profound disruption in a person's life, often marked by isolation, stigma, and the loss of identity. For individuals belonging to the LGBTQAI+ community, imprisonment intensifies these experiences due to the intersection of sexual orientation, gender identity, and systemic discrimination. The LGBTQAI+ population comprising lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer or questioning, asexual, intersex, and other gender-diverse individuals continues to face deep-rooted prejudice and marginalization across multiple social institutions (Human Rights Campaign, 2024).

Within correctional facilities, these individuals often experience heightened vulnerability, where social biases are magnified by rigid institutional norms. Globally, studies indicate that LGBTQAI+ persons deprived of liberty experience disproportionate rates of violence, harassment, and neglect in comparison with their heterosexual and cisgender counterparts (Serra & Moral, 2023). Many are subjected to verbal abuse, sexual assault, and exclusionary practices such as denial of gender-affirming healthcare or segregation inconsistent with their gender identity. These experiences contribute to deep psychological distress, trauma, and internalized stigma, affecting their rehabilitation and reintegration into society (Mogul et al., 2019).

Moreover, Violence is even higher for transgender women who are assigned to male prisons. They suffer physical violence being beaten up, sexually abused, or becoming servants perpetrated by other inmates and prison staff. For instance, a transgender woman in an American prison reported that she have been beaten and raped because of being a transgender with a female breasts and feminine. In her case, there were no consequences for the inmates who abused her and for the prison staff that did not intervene to prevent it. In another case, a

transgender woman in a Mexican male prison reported that guards practiced sexual violence and forced them into prostitution, threatening to send them to isolation cells or to the blocks with the worst reputation for violence (Walters et al.,2024).

In the study of Soriano and Corpuz (2025) it was revealed the incarcerated LGBTQIA+ member's sexual orientation and gender expression exposes them to being targeted by harassment, often even before incarceration. This vulnerability was worsened by societal assumptions about LGBTQ individuals being sexually available or promiscuous. One of their participant shared how people assumed that all gays are like that, using threats and physical force to coerce compliance. Others recounted how they were coerced during drinking sessions, with sexual advances being framed as obligatory, expected, or even transactional.

Furthermore, in Zamboanga Province's Jail, a reality marked by systemic discrimination, gender based victimization and deep psychological distress has been experienced by the lesbian and gay inmates. These individuals struggle for dignity, acceptance and belonging inside the prison. Ultimately, despite the pervasive stigma and discrimination they endure, lesbian and gay persons deprived of liberty continue to seek acceptance and a sense of community, reinforcing the critical need for inclusive, gender-sensitive correctional policies that uphold their rights and promote their holistic rehabilitation (Zoilo & Macaranas, 2025).

With that, the researchers will conduct the research study to know and understand the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQAI+ individuals specifically in Butuan City Jail, focusing on how they experience identity expression, discrimination, coping mechanisms, and resilience. It seeks to uncover the psychological, emotional, and social dimensions of being both a member of a marginalized group and an inmate. By analyzing these experiences, the study aims to reveal how institutional structures and personal agency intersect in shaping identity and survival within a carceral environment.

This study adds to the growing field of gender and carceral studies by offering a deeper look into how sexuality and incarceration intersect within the Philippine setting. Its findings can help correctional leaders and policymakers create more inclusive and gender-sensitive policies that uphold the rights and well-being of LGBTQAI+ persons deprived of liberty. On a social level, the study gives space to voices that are often unheard, encouraging greater empathy, fairness, and social justice. Ultimately, it hopes to inspire reforms that ensure every person behind bars regardless of gender identity or sexual orientation is treated with dignity, respect, and humanity.

1.2 Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in one theoretical perspective, Minority Stress Theory that provides a lens for understanding the lived experiences of LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty within carceral institutions.

Minority Stress Theory, which explains how individuals belonging to marginalized sexual and gender identities experience unique, chronic stressors due to stigma, discrimination, and social exclusion. These stressors both external and internal can negatively affect their mental health and well-being, especially in environments that amplify prejudice, such as correctional facilities. Incarcerated LGBTQAI+ individuals often face harassment, isolation, and denial of identity expression, leading to heightened psychological distress. Applying Minority Stress Theory helps the study explore how participants manage identity-based stress, develop coping mechanisms, and build resilience within carceral settings. This aligns with the work of Frost and Meyer (2023), who reaffirmed the continued relevance of minority stress theory in understanding the lived realities of sexual and gender minorities.

Research among transgender and gender non-conforming populations (Testa et al.,2015), further validated Minority Stress Theory by documenting how gender-based stigma contributes

to heightened risks of psychological distress, suicidality, and barriers to healthcare. Moreover, (Juster et al. 2015) that physiological and neurological correlates of minority stress show that chronic exposure to stigma may affect biological stress systems. Additionally, Sutter & Perrin (2016) demonstrate that racial minority LGBTQ+ individuals experience compounded forms of stigma, intensifying stress exposure and deepening disparities.

According to Puckett et al. (2017) that minority stress theory applies globally, though cultural contexts shape the nature and intensity of minority stress. Mallory et al. (2021) consistently affirm the robustness of Minority Stress Theory in explaining mental health inequalities among sexual and gender minorities. Although, the literature strongly supports Minority Stress Theory as a comprehensive framework for understanding how societal stigma shapes health outcomes and continues to guide contemporary research, clinical practice, and policy advocacy focused on reducing LGBTQ+ health disparities.

1.3 Review of Related Literature

The incarceration of LGBTQIA+ persons has emerged as a critical area of inquiry in recent years, as research consistently highlights their disproportionate representation in prisons and jails heightened vulnerability to victimization, and limited access to health and gender-affirming services. Grounded in theories of minority stress, existing literature reveals how structural discrimination, stigma, and institutional neglect shape the lived realities of LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty. This review surveys global, regional, and local studies to situate the present research within broader scholarly and policy discussions, while identifying gaps that necessitate a phenomenological exploration of the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members in the Philippine context.

It is now well established that LGBTQ+ people experience a higher prevalence of mental ill-health than the general population, with poorer mental health outcomes. For transgender

people specifically, this relates to higher level of depression, suicidality, interpersonal trauma, substance use disorders and general distress. LGBTQ+ people who are in prison experience a number of additional challenges. These factors are not singular, they are interlocking, giving rise to a vast inequality in the well-being of those in prisons compared to their heterosexual or cisgender counterparts. Among the factors of concern are institutional stigma buoyed by pervasive myths and stereotypes about the population. For example, research has shown that the discrimination, alienation and victimization that LGBTQ+ people can experience in general society is often mirrored and intensified in the prison environment. However, this stigma can also inform institutional culture and behavior toward inmates and may reinforce lack of agency among prison staff regarding how to work and support this population (Int. J. Environ. Res. Public Health, 2021).

Based on the study of Manaya and Danao (2025), entitled Rainbows Behind Bars A Phenomenological Inquiry on Gay Filipino Persons Deprived of Liberty, it was revealed that the lived experiences of gay persons deprived of liberty are characterized by inadequate essential provisions, social intimacy, life-changing realization, and evolving perceptions of jail life. Despite challenges such as overcrowding, limited budgets, and insufficient medical supplies, the participants found emotional fulfillment through meaningful relationships and social connection inside the facility. Their incarceration became a transformative journey that deepened their understanding of life, strengthened family ties, and renewed faith in the Divine, leading to hope and personal growth. Moreover, the study highlighted the positive treatment of gay persons deprived of liberty by fellow inmates, jail personnel, and the BJMP, reflecting the institution's adherence to humane and developmental correctional practices. The absence of discrimination, harassment, and exploitation, alongside access to self-development programs, demonstrated a respectful and rights-based environment within the correctional setting.

International norms and guidance emphasize non-discrimination and humane treatment of all persons deprived of liberty. The United Nations Nelson Mandela Rules (UNODC, 2015) and specialized monitoring frameworks (Penal Reform International & APT, 2016) articulate protections relevant to LGBTQ+ PDLs ranging from safe allocation and accommodation to the prohibition of discriminatory denial of services. Nevertheless, the gap between these international standards and on-the-ground practices persist in many jurisdictions, as monitoring reports and human-rights documentation reveal inconsistent implementation.

International standards provide a clear normative framework for addressing these risks. The United Nations Revised Standard Minimum Rules for the Treatment of Prisoners the Mandela Rules enshrine basic protections for all prisoners dignity, protection from torture and ill-treatment, and access to health care which form the baseline obligation for states and correctional agencies. Complementing the Mandela Rules, the Bangkok Rules United Nations Rules for the Treatment of Women Prisoners and Non-custodial Measures for Women and related gender-responsive instruments emphasize that custodial policies and practices must be sensitive to gendered vulnerabilities and the specific needs of marginalized groups principles that are applicable to gender-diverse and sexual minority detainees. The Yogyakarta Principles plus ten further apply international human-rights law to sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, and sex characteristics, clarifying states duties to prevent discrimination, ensure access to health including gender-affirming care, and provide effective remedies for rights violations.

Bridging policy and practice requires operationalizing these standards within correctional systems adopting clear complaint and referral mechanisms, training staff in SOGIE competency, ensuring medically necessary, gender-affirming healthcare including continuation of hormone therapy, providing safe housing alternatives without punitive isolation, and monitoring

compliance through independent oversight. Philippine policy documents (BJMP) and international instruments together set the legal and ethical obligations, human-rights reports indicate that realizing these obligations on the ground remains the essential challenge for policymakers, correctional administrators, and civil society actors.

National policy in the Philippines has begun to acknowledge the specific vulnerabilities of LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty the Bureau of Jail Management and Penology issued a formal Policy on the Treatment of LGBTQIA PDL that sets out guidelines for admission, classification, housing, and the protection of LGBTQI detainees, signaling institutional recognition of risk and the need for gender-sensitive procedures (BJMP, 2018). However, human-rights monitoring and country reports continue to document gaps in protection, enforcement, and implementation pointing to persistent incidents of discrimination, violence, and barriers to effective complaint mechanisms for sexual and gender minorities in custody.

Lived experience of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members within correctional facility

The lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ people reflect a complex interplay of vulnerability, resilience, structural discrimination, and personal agency. They face elevated risks of violence, isolation, and inadequate healthcare within environments that often invalidate their identities. Yet, amid these challenges, they cultivate community, advocate for their rights, and navigate the system with remarkable strength. Their stories provide critical insight into how correctional institutions can better uphold dignity, safety, and equity. The lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ people reveal how identity, power, and institutional practices collide in ways that profoundly shape daily life behind bars. Their realities cannot be understood solely through the lens of vulnerability; they also illuminate the ways people resist, adapt, and build meaning in environments that often fail-or refuse-to recognize their humanity.

The lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ individuals reveal how identity, stigma, and institutional structures intersect within the walls of correctional facilities. While global studies acknowledge the heightened vulnerabilities of queer persons in detention such as discrimination, limited gender-affirming support, and threats to safety research in the Philippine context remains limited. Within facilities shaped by heteronormative and binary policies, LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty often navigate daily life differently from the general population, negotiating their sense of self amid rigid rules and social hierarchies. This study examines their lived experiences to understand how they cope, assert their identities, and find resilience within restrictive environments, with the goal of informing more humane, inclusive, and gender-sensitive practices in the country's correctional system.

Systemic Discrimination

People who identify as LGBTQ+ and are in prison often experience many additional challenges. Once in prison, there is systemic discrimination against imprisoned LGBTQ+ people and a lack of understanding and concern regarding their care, treatment and support needs. While there is growing interest in their protection and that of other vulnerable populations in prison settings, little is known about their views and experiences regarding their distinct psychosocial needs (Int. J. Environ. Res. Public Health, 2021).

LGBTQ+ people are disproportionately represented in correction facilities. Within the binary structure of the prison system, the needs of LGBTQ+ people tend to be largely ignored, leading to feelings of helplessness, isolation and at times, humiliation. While there are promising efforts to improve the prison environment, individual and institutional barriers exist and conspire to make being LGBTQ+ in prison a challenging experience.

One of the most pervasive forms of systematic discrimination occurs in the classification and housing of transgender inmates. Jenness and Fenstermaker (2014) conducted extensive

research on transgender prisoners and found that most correctional systems place incarcerated individuals based on sex assigned at birth rather than gender identity. This means that transgender women are typically placed in men's prisons, where they face extremely high levels of harassment, sexual assault, and physical violence.

Another layer of systematic discrimination involves direct harassment from correctional staff. (Jennings et al., 2015) found that LGBTQIA+ prisoners often experience verbal abuse, derogatory slurs, intentional misgendering, and discriminatory enforcement of rules by officers. Many inmates report that staff not only fail to protect them but actively encourage other inmates to target them. These experiences are compounded by power imbalances officers can control access to food, privileges, medical care, and disciplinary reports. LGBTQIA+ inmates frequently state that staff harassment makes it impossible to seek help or report abuse. Fear of retaliation prevents many from filing complaints, reinforcing a culture of silence that protects discriminatory factors. This reflects how systematic discrimination is maintained through institutional authority and lack of accountability structures.

Sexual Victimization

Quantitative and qualitative research consistently finds high rates of sexual victimization and custodial abuse among LGBTQ+ incarcerated people, with transgender prisoners particularly at risk. The U.S. Bureau of Justice Statistics estimated that roughly one-third of transgender inmates in prisons and jails reported sexual victimization by other inmates or staff in the prior twelve months or since admission (BJS, 2015). Qualitative studies corroborate these findings and further describe how housing placement, staff attitudes, and informal prison hierarchies contribute to vulnerability and coercive dynamics (Bromdal et al., 2023).

Philippines consistently shows that LGBTQ+ persons deprived of liberty experience a heightened risk of sexual victimization due to entrenched prison hierarchies and discriminatory

attitudes. Relis (2016) documented how gay inmates in the Leyte Regional Prison were frequently subjected to rape, coercive sexual acts, and harassment by both fellow inmates and, at times, correctional staff. These abuses are often rooted in the perception that LGBTQ+ detainees are easy targets, reinforcing cycles of exploitation within a patriarchal, hypermasculine prison culture. As a result, queer inmates are more vulnerable to predatory behavior, especially in overcrowded and poorly monitored detention environments.

A report by Just Detention International (2015) characterized sexual violence in Philippine jails and prisons as a systemic human rights issue, worsened by inadequate supervision, weak grievance mechanisms, and a lack of gender-sensitive protocols. Although the Bureau of Jail Management and Penology (BJMP, 2018) introduced a policy recognizing that LGBTQI Persons Deprived of Liberty's face heightened danger of humiliation, discrimination, and sexual assault, implementation across facilities remains inconsistent. Many jails still lack designated safe spaces or trained personnel, leaving vulnerable detainees without formal protection from abuse.

Throughout their life course, LGBTQA+ individuals experience high rates of victimization. They are subject to unwanted attention, harassment, abuse, and violence within a context of pervasive homophobia, transphobia, and racism, among other sources of power and privilege, by members of society and across all components of the legal system. Much like their non-LGBTQA+ counterparts, LGBTQA+ people of color are at increased risk of victimization and incarceration. However, being a person of color and LGBTQA+ increases the likelihood of victimization and involvement with the legal system and, ultimately, incarceration at disproportionate rates. This chapter examines LGBTQA+ victimization through an intersectional lens to broaden the understanding of Queer issues within the US carceral system and the complexities of multiplicative marginalization. First is an overview of the link between victimization and system involvement among LGBTQA+ people, often beginning with contact in the juvenile justice system.

Next is a discussion of the contexts of incarceration and supervision that cause increased vulnerability and secondary victimization among LGBTQA+ individuals (Avalos & Boppre, 2023).

Another major concern is the widespread underreporting of sexual victimization. Soriano and Corpuz (2025), in their phenomenological study of LGBTQ inmates in Pampanga, found that many victims choose not to disclose incidents due to fear of retaliation, lack of trust in authorities, and the stigma associated with reporting sexual violence in a punitive environment. Participants described feeling powerless and invisible within the system, noting that some staff members downplay or ignore their complaints. This culture of silence normalizes abuse and denies victims access to justice, psychological support, and institutional protection. personnel, leaving vulnerable detainees without formal protection from abuse.

In Philippine jails, LGBTQ+ persons deprived of liberty face heightened vulnerability to sexual victimization, often beginning with forced conformity and identity suppression. For instance, in Manila City Jail, a trans woman, pseudonymously called Nicole, described being compelled to discard her feminine presentation upon entry to the men's dormitory, highlighting how institutional pressures can force LGBTQ+ inmates to hide their identity for personal safety. Soon after, she was propositioned for a same-sex wedding, a common arrangement among gay and transgender inmates intended as protection but which can also involve coercion and abuse. Similarly, Noli Cano, another gay PDL in Navotas Detention Center, reported a direct incident of sexual assault when a cell leader attempted to assault him in the communal shower, illustrating the pervasive risk of inmate-on-inmate abuse (PCIJ, 2022).

Crushing fear and lack of acceptance are the two identified experiences of their transgender identity. Feelings of fear included fear of sexual harassment, fear of sexual and physical assault, fear of being used a sexual pawn and, in one instance, fear of discovery of their transgender identity. In relation to lack of acceptance of their transgender identity, participants

were not given the option of being placed to a women's institution, despite openly identifying as transgender. Some participants were placed on special needs units where they were strip searched like they were men, were not identified by the proper pronoun and preferred name and were not provided with gender-appropriate clothing and grooming products (Vandenbroek,2020).

Institutional recognition of these risks is evident in official policies. The Bureau of Jail Management and Penology acknowledges that LGBTQI PDLs are prone to sexual abuse, humiliation, and violence, yet implementation of protective measures remains inconsistent, leaving many inmates exposed to harm from both other prisoners and staff (BJMP, 2018). Collectively, these situations reveal a pattern in Philippine correctional facilities: LGBTQ+ PDLs are forced to balance concealment, protective relationships, and personal resilience, all while navigating environments where sexual victimization is a real and pervasive threat.

Mental Health Issues

Mental health does not exist on its own. It is an integral and essential part of overall health, which can be defined in at least three ways as the absence of disease, as a state of the organism that allows the full performance of all its functions or as a state of balance within oneself and between oneself and one's physical and social environment. Mental disorder has been recognized as a significant public health concern and one of the leading causes of disability worldwide, particularly with the loss of productive years of the sufferer's life (Sartorius, 2016).

Hatzenbuehler and Keyes (2019) examined how LGBTQIA+ prisoners are disproportionately placed in solitary confinement due to their sexual orientation or gender identity. Many prisons justify solitary confinement as protection, but LGBTQIA+ inmates report it as a form of punishment that worsens mental health issues. In the study, inmates described severe anxiety, hallucinations, depression, and emotional deterioration due to prolonged

isolation. Solitary confinement becomes a systemic practice used to manage LGBTQIA+ bodies rather than addressing the root issues of discrimination and unsafe environments. Hatzenbuehler and Keyes argue that these practices are rooted in structural stigma where institutions enforce policies that isolate marginalized individuals under the guise of safety. In reality, solitary confinement often worsens the vulnerability of LGBTQIA+ people rather than protecting them.

Based on the study of Lydon et al. (2015) Many LGBTQIA+ participants reported that correctional officers were the *primary* source of discrimination, which intensifies psychological harm from being mocked, misgendered, humiliated, and targeted by correctional officers on a daily basis. This constant verbal abuse contributes to feelings of worthlessness, shame, and fear, which strongly correlate with symptoms of post-traumatic stress disorder and chronic anxiety. Because officers hold immense power over housing, discipline, and healthcare, LGBTQIA+ inmates often feel trapped and unable to seek help for mental health concerns. This lack of power and constant mistreatment fosters learned helplessness, a psychological state where individuals begin to believe they have no control over their circumstances, leading to depression and self-harm.

INFLUENCE OF INCARCERATION

One of the influence of incarceration and crime involvement among LGBTQAI+ individuals is due to a complex web of family rejection, homelessness, unemployment, poverty, bias, and discrimination, LGBTQ+ individuals may turn to criminalized activities like theft, panhandling, and sex work in order to survive. Heightened police surveillance increases the likelihood of LGBTQ+ individuals being arrested and charged for forms of criminalized survival. LGBTQ+ individuals with a history of criminal legal system involvement experience heightened discrimination and exclusion from employment, education, and other opportunities because of their records, leading to continued homelessness, unemployment, and poverty (Hereth,2022).

Rehabilitation, a cornerstone of South Africa's correctional system, is the focus of this research. The study aimed to understand how inmates perceive these rehabilitation programs, a crucial aspect for improving outcomes and addressing systemic issues like recidivism. The research delved into the effectiveness, relevance, and accessibility of these programs as perceived by inmates. It also emphasize the pivotal role of the Sense of Coherence (SOC) framework, a key psychological concept that measures an individual's ability to manage stress and maintain a sense of well-being. This framework was used to understand how inmates' perceptions of their rehabilitation experiences influenced their self-perception. This emphasis on the SOC framework provides a deeper understanding of the psychological aspects of rehabilitation. Employing a constructivist approach, a research methodology that focuses on understanding the subjective experiences of individuals, the study used semi-structured interviews with inmates who had participated in rehabilitation programs. These interviews aimed to uncover how engagement with rehabilitation had influenced inmates' self-perception, including their attitudes and beliefs about themselves. Thematic analysis of the qualitative data provided insights into the significant personal growth fostered by these programs. The growth in communication, emotional regulation, and conflict resolution can inspire and motivate further improvements in the correctional system (Ndimande & Bonginkosi, 2024).

Individual narratives are often shaped by social relationships and the specific circumstances in which people are embedded, and this is especially true for incarcerated LGBTQ individuals. Within carceral environments, their stories are influenced not only by personal identity but also by the dynamics of social relationships marked by stigma, surveillance, and varying levels of acceptance or hostility. Interactions with correctional staff, other incarcerated people, and limited support networks shape how LGBTQ individuals interpret and articulate their experiences. Likewise, the restrictive and often punitive circumstances of incarceration such as

segregated housing, limited access to affirming healthcare, and exposure to discrimination or violence frame the types of stories they can tell about themselves and their lives. These conditions may push individuals toward certain narrative forms, such as ones emphasizing resilience, survival, or concealment, while constraining other expressions of identity or experience. As a result, the narratives produced by incarcerated LGBTQ people are deeply intertwined with the social and institutional forces that structure their daily lives, shaping not only what is told but also what feels tellable in such contexts (Thomas et al., 2021).

Based on the study of Relis et al., (2016) in Leyte Regional Prison Poverty is the most salient theme identified in the narratives of the Filipino gay prisoners. Moreover, the participants identified this experience as central to the different aspects of their lives, from their childhood up to their imprisonment in the Leyte Regional Prison. On one hand, some of them were separated from their immediate families at a very young age due to poverty. Since the participants grew up in families living in poverty, they spent most of their formative years observing and going through the difficulties of their families' condition. This became one of the factors that led them to make a living out of illegal activities, believing that these would easily improve their situation.

Coping Mechanism

Spiritual or religious coping

Incarcerated individuals, particularly LGBTQ+ persons deprived of liberty (PDLs), employ diverse coping strategies to manage the stress, discrimination, and psychological challenges of confinement. Spiritual or religious coping is one of the most common strategies in the Philippine context. Many PDLs turn to prayer, faith, and participation in spiritual services to gain inner strength and resilience, helping them navigate both identity-related stress and the harsh realities of prison life (Soriano & Corpuz, 2025)

Identity management and silence

Identity management and silence also serve as adaptive strategies, as LGBTQ+ inmates conceal their sexuality or gender expression, avoid conflicts, and carefully regulate self-presentation to minimize harassment and violence, a phenomenon documented both locally and internationally (Moyano & Egea, 2021).

Self-improvement and Purposeful Engagement

Also widely utilized PDLs participate in educational programs, recreational activities, or structured routines that help maintain a sense of purpose, foster discipline, and reframe incarceration as an opportunity for personal growth (Macabago et al., 2020).

Psychological withdrawal or isolation

Conversely, some inmates adopt psychological withdrawal or isolation as a coping strategy. While avoiding social interaction or emotionally withdrawing can protect inmates from immediate harm, this avoidance may increase long-term stress and mental health vulnerability (Barolo & Vicente, 2019).

Resilience and Moral Reorientation

Finally, resilience and moral reorientation emerge as central themes in coping, especially among LGBTQ+ inmates. Many engage in introspection, moral reflection, or spiritual rebirth, using incarceration as a period for personal transformation, reaffirming self-worth, and asserting psychological agency despite oppressive conditions (Moyano & Egea, 2021). Collectively, these coping mechanisms, spirituality, identity management, social support, purposeful engagement, withdrawal, and resilience highlight the agency of incarcerated individuals and underscore the complex interplay of psychological, social, and cultural factors in navigating prison life.

1.4 Specific Objectives

This study aims to explore the Lived experiences, perceptions, and coping mechanisms of LGBTQAI+ inmates.

1. To describe the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members within the correctional facility.
2. To analyze how incarceration influences their self-identity, personal growth, and outlook on rehabilitation.
3. To identify the coping mechanisms and adaptive strategies employed by LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty (PDLs) in dealing with their incarceration.

1.5 Scope And Delimitation

This study focuses on exploring the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQAI+ in a correctional facility at Bureau of Jail Management and Penology Butuan City Jail, Libertad,Butuan City Agusan del Norte. It aims to understand their personal narratives, coping mechanisms, and identity expressions while navigating the challenges of incarceration. Guided by the Minority Stress Theory and the Queer Pathways Framework, the study examines how discrimination, stigma, and institutional policies influence the psychosocial well-being and self-concept of LGBTQAI+ inmates. The research gives voice to their unique experiences, allowing a deeper understanding of how incarceration intersects with gender identity and sexual orientation.

The study is limited to adult inmates who openly identify as members of the LGBTQAI+ community and are currently detained in one correctional facility within the chosen province. Only those who voluntarily participate and provide informed consent are included, ensuring ethical compliance and data authenticity. The study will employ a qualitative phenomenological approach, using in-depth interviews and thematic analysis to capture the essence of participants lived experiences.

The delimitation of this research lies in its geographical and population boundaries. It does not include perspectives of prison staff, non-LGBTQ inmates, or released individuals, as the study centers solely on the firsthand accounts of LGBTQAI+ persons currently experiencing incarceration. Time and logistical constraints may also limit the number of participants and institutions involved. Additionally, findings will reflect the contextual realities of the specific facilities studied and may not be representative of all prisons nationwide. Despite these limitations, the study aspires to contribute valuable insights to correctional management, human rights advocacy, and gender-sensitive rehabilitation programs, highlighting the need for inclusive and humane treatment of all incarcerated individuals.

1.6 Definition of Terms

For the clarity of the study, the following terms are defined either conceptually or operationally.

Coping Mechanisms. refer to the adaptive and resilience-building strategies employed by LGBTQAI+ inmates to survive and maintain self-identity while in confinement.

Correctional Facility. Refers to the selected prisons or detention centers where the study's participants are currently incarcerated.

Identity expression. Pertains to how incarcerated LGBTQAI+ members present and assert their gender and sexual identities while inside correctional facilities, including how institutional norms, safety concerns, and discrimination influence the freedom or restriction of such expression.

Incarceration. Pertains to the period of imprisonment experienced by LGBTQAI+ individuals within correctional facilities where their gender identity and sexual orientation may influence their treatment and experiences.

LGBTQAI+. Refers to inmates within correctional facilities who identify with one or more of these identities and who voluntarily share their lived experiences during the research interviews.

Lived Experiences. Refer to the firsthand narratives and reflections of LGBTQAI+ inmates regarding their daily life, treatment, coping, and identity expression while incarcerated.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

This study employed a qualitative research design using a phenomenological approach. Phenomenology is concerned with exploring and describing the lived experiences of individuals in order to capture the essence and meaning of their realities (Creswell & Poth, 2018). Since the present study seeks to understand how incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members make sense of their daily lives, navigate challenges such as stigma and discrimination, and develop coping mechanisms within correctional facilities, a phenomenological design is most appropriate.

By using this approach, the study prioritizes the voices and perspectives of participants, allowing their narratives to emerge through in-depth interviews and thematic analysis. Rather than testing hypotheses, the research design focuses on describing, interpreting, and thematically analyzing participants lived experiences to reveal patterns of meaning.

2.2 Research Locale

The study was conducted in a correctional facility at Bureau of Jail Management and Penology Butuan City Jail, Libertad,Butuan City Agusan del Norte, where LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty are housed. This facility was chosen based on accessibility, the presence of LGBTQIA+ inmates, and the willingness of administrators to permit the conduct of interviews. The correctional setting provides the contextual backdrop where participants lived experiences, challenges, and coping mechanisms unfold.

2.3 Research Respondent

The study's population consisted of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members who self-identified as lesbian and gay. These individuals are part of a marginalized group within the prison population

and often face unique challenges related to stigma, discrimination, and access to gender-affirming care.

2.4 Research Instrument

The primary research instrument was the researcher as the main data-gathering tool, supported by a semi-structured interview guide developed from the research questions. The guide included open-ended questions on participants' experiences, challenges, and coping strategies. An audio recorder and field notes were also utilized with participants' consent.

The data collection procedure began with securing formal approval from the prison authorities and the ethics review board to ensure that the study adhered to institutional and ethical standards. After obtaining clearance, the researcher sought the informed consent of participants by explaining the purpose of the study, guaranteeing confidentiality, and emphasizing the voluntary nature of their participation. Following this, in-depth, face-to-face interviews were conducted in private and secure spaces within the correctional facility to promote openness and ensure participants' comfort. Each interview was audio-recorded, with permission, and supported by field notes. Finally, the interviews were transcribed verbatim, after which participants were invited to review and validate the transcripts through member checking to ensure accuracy and credibility of the data.

2.5 Ethical Standards

This study strictly adhered to established ethical standards in conducting research with human participants, particularly with marginalized and vulnerable groups such as incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members.

First, informed consent was obtained from all participants. They were fully briefed about the purpose, scope, and procedures of the study, as well as their rights to refuse participation or

withdraw at any time without penalty. Participation was entirely voluntary, and no form of coercion was applied.

Second, confidentiality and anonymity were ensured throughout the research process. Pseudonyms were assigned to all participants, and any identifying information was removed from transcripts and reports. Data was securely stored in password-protected files, accessible only to the researcher.

Third, the study emphasized respect for participants' dignity, privacy, and identity. Sensitivity to gender identity and sexual orientation was prioritized in formulating interview questions, conducting interactions, and presenting findings.

Fourth, the researcher upheld the principles of beneficence and non-maleficence. Every effort was made to minimize potential psychological discomfort, and counseling referrals were prepared in case interviews evoked distress.

Finally, research clearance and approval were secured from the Institutional Ethics Review Board and the prison authorities before conducting data collection. The study complied with both institutional guidelines and international ethical principles such as the Belmont Report's principles of respect for persons, beneficence, and justice.

Through these measures, the study ensured that participants' rights, safety, and well-being were protected, while maintaining the credibility and integrity of the research.

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This phenomenological study on the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQAI+ members does not involve the creation of new technologies, processes, or products that require patent protection, instead, it focuses on documentation and interpreting narrative experiences of the incarcerated LGBTQAI+ members. However, the study will produce original qualitative materials such as interview transcripts, thematic analyses, and interpretive reports. It remains

essential to ensure that all research outputs are properly protected, to prevent unauthorized access, misuse, or misrepresentation of participants' responses and for the study's academic contributions.

B. Informed Consent

In the study on the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQAI+ members, participants were thoroughly informed about the purpose of the study, procedures, potential risks, and anticipated benefits through a clear and accessible orientation before the data collection. The researcher will explain how their narrative statement would be used, the measures taken to protect their confidentiality, and their right to withdraw at any point without penalty or impact on their status. Written informed consent was obtained from all participants to ensure voluntary participation.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

In accordance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012 of the Philippines, participant data in this study was collected and handled with strict attention to privacy and confidentiality. Participants' information will be anonymized to protect identities, and use code identifiers, the data was securely stored to avoid any disclosure of sensitive information. Participants' answers will be anonymized according to their codes. In regard with the third parties required explicit consent from participants, ensuring their privacy was fully respected throughout the stud

D. Voluntary Participation

The Participants participation was entirely voluntary, with no form of coercion or force exerted on potential respondents within the correctional setting. Participants were clearly informed that their involvement was optional and that they had the right to decline or withdraw from the study at any point without facing consequences or effects on their privileges, treatment, or status within the correctional institutions. Ethical guidelines were strictly followed throughout

the research, upholding voluntary participation was a core ethical priority, ensuring that the voices of LGBTQAI+, persons deprived of liberty were answered freely and authentically.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

The study will protect participants from physical, psychological, and emotional well-being by ensuring interviews were conducted in safe, private settings without any discomfort, unless needed for safety. Participants were also offered support, including access to mental health professionals, counselors, LGBTQAI+ support groups, and emergency staff, in case the interviews caused distress and discomfort.

F. Beneficence

This study will promote beneficence by contributing valuable insights into the experiences of incarcerated LGBTQAI+ individuals, to understand their lived experiences in academically and society and support the arising LGBTQ+ to the inclusion community. The findings will also be available to participants upon request, allowing them to benefit directly from the knowledge gained through the study**.**

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

In this study, participants were selected based on clear and transparent inclusion and exclusion criteria to ensure a fair and equitable process. Participants from diverse backgrounds, ensuring that no one was excluded or discriminated against based on race, gender, sexual orientation, or other personal characteristics. This approach allowed the study to capture a wide range of perspectives and experiences, particularly important for understanding the lived experiences faced by incarcerated LGBTQAI+ individuals. Focus remained on human participants who were directly relevant to the study's objectives, ensuring that the principles of justice and fairness guided every aspect of participant selection.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

The study will be consistent and thoughtful methods were used throughout data collection and analysis. Interviews followed a structured yet flexible approach, allowing participants to share their experiences openly while keeping the process reliable. The researcher carefully reviewed and cross-checked transcripts and discussed interpretations together to reduce errors and enhance trustworthiness. Any possible biases or limitations were openly acknowledged, ensuring that the findings truthfully reflect the participants' perspectives and lived experiences.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The research findings will be reported truthfully and transparently, reflecting the data and experiences of participants without alteration or misrepresentation. All sources, including copyrighted and patented materials, were properly cited and credited to the owner, ensuring the study maintains the highest standards of academic honesty.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

The research did not involve any patented technologies, however, when copyrighted materials such as software or literature were used, appropriate permissions were obtained and all sources were properly credited. This ensured that the study complied with intellectual property laws and respected the rights of the original creators.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

For human participants, the study ensured that everyone was fully informed of all potential risks and benefits before participating, and voluntary consent was obtained to uphold their autonomy and safety. Although the study did not involve animals, any protocols that could have included animal use were prepared in accordance with ethical clearance requirements, ensuring that if animals were involved, humane treatment standards would be strictly followed.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Related Technologies

The study responsibly utilized AI tools to assist with organizing and analyzing qualitative data, improving efficiency without compromising the integrity of the research. AI was used solely to support tasks such as coding and pattern recognition, while all interpretations and conclusions were carefully reviewed and validated by the researcher. Measures were taken to ensure that AI outputs were accurate, transparent, and did not introduce bias, maintaining full accountability for the study's findings.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Ethical approval for this study was obtained from the Ethics Review Board of Saint Michael College of Caraga, ensuring that all research procedures complied with established ethical standards for human subjects. Approval will be expected to be granted, confirming that the study met requirements for participant safety, informed consent, and confidentiality before data collection began.

2.7 Data and Analysis Plan and Procedure

The primary data for this study consisted of in-depth, semi-structured interviews with incarcerated LGBTQIA+ persons. These interviews generated rich, descriptive narratives that provided insights into participants lived experiences, challenges within correctional facilities, and the coping mechanisms they employed. Supplementary data, such as field notes and institutional documents were also considered to support triangulation.

The analysis followed a phenomenological method, which ensures that findings remain faithful to participants' accounts while allowing the researcher to extract thematic meanings. The process involved the following steps first familiarization with the interview transcripts through repeated reading, second extraction of significant statements relevant to the phenomenon, third formulation of meanings from these statements, fourth clustering of meanings into themes that

capture shared experiences, and last is development of an exhaustive description that integrates all themes, and validation of findings by returning to participants for confirmation.

A purposive sampling technique was used to select participants who were able and willing to articulate their experiences. The sample size was determined based on the principle of data saturation, which in phenomenological studies typically ranges to 10 participants. Participants were selected according to the following inclusion criteria currently incarcerated at Bureau of Jail Management and Penology Butuan Cityl Jail, Libertad,Butuan City, the chosen correctional facility, self-identify as LGBTQIA+, and voluntarily agree to participate in the study.

To maintain trustworthiness, the study employed triangulation, peer debriefing, and an audit trail throughout the analysis. Qualitative analysis software may be used to assist with coding and theme development, though the primary interpretation remains researcher-driven. Ultimately, the analysis plan aimed to distill the essence of the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members, providing a holistic understanding of how they navigate incarceration while negotiating their gender and sexual identities.

INTERVIEW GUIDE QUESTIONS:

Specific Objective 1:

To describe the lived experiences of incarcerated LGBTQIA+ members within the correctional facility.

(Focus: identity-related challenges, Interpersonal treatment, institutional improvements)

1. Can you describe your daily experiences in the facility and how being an LGBTQIA+ individual shapes those experiences?

2. How do you feel you are treated by correctional staff and fellow inmates in relation to your sexual orientation or gender identity?

3. What challenges or difficulties have you faced in accessing healthcare, safety, or support services while incarcerated?

4. Can you share any moments or situations in the facility where you felt affirmed, respected, or supported as an LGBTQIA+ person?

5. What changes or improvements would you recommend to make the correctional environment more inclusive and supportive for LGBTQIA+ individuals?

Specific Objective 2:

To analyze how incarceration influences their self-identity, personal growth, and outlook on rehabilitation.

(focus: emotional development, future goals, factors that impact views on rehabilitation)

1. How has being incarcerated affected the way you see yourself as an LGBTQIA+ individual?

2. Can you describe any ways in which your time in the facility has influenced your personal growth or personal development?

3.What experiences inside the correctional facility have challenged or strengthened your sense of self?

4. How have your experiences here shaped your thoughts or expectations about rehabilitation and life after release?

5.What support, programs, or interactions within the facility have influenced your outlook on changing or improving your life moving forward?

Specific Objective 3:

To identify the coping mechanisms and adaptive strategies employed by LGBTQIA+ persons deprived of liberty in dealing with their incarceration.

(focus: coping mechanisms, emotional and psychological stress, maintaining mental well-being)

1. What strategies or behaviors do you use to manage stress or emotional challenges while incarcerated?

2. How do you maintain your sense of identity and personal well-being inside the facility?

3. Are there people, groups, or relationships within the facility that help you cope with the challenges of incarceration?

4. What activities, routines, or habits have you found helpful in adjusting to life in the correctional environment?

5. How do you handle situations where you feel unsafe, discriminated against, or misunderstood because of your sexual orientation or gender identity?

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